CRICKET WORLD CUP, 1983

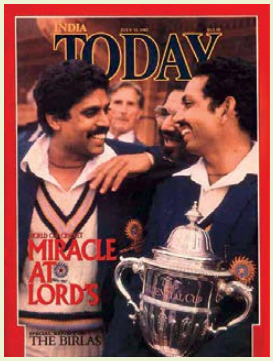
THE IDEA THAT WE CAN WIN

Yes, even that was not there when Kapil Dev, himself only 24, led a bunch of devil-may-care no-hopers right up to the summit of world cricket. For India, it was the equivalent of the Moon Landing—except unplanned and unimagined. What changed after that? Everything.

BY SUNIL MENON

Mohinder Amarnath, unrushed even at the cusp of history, in that slow waltz run-up of his, like a glacial sheet that's only contemplating melting. Michael Holding, his gazelle-like elegance frozen in the headlights at the crease. Umpire Dickie Bird, pert as ever, raising his finger to 12 o'clock. You could call it a sporting moment. But there was an epochal quality to this victory of the underdogs. Bird, as charming a symbol of the old world as you want, was signalling the birth of a new world order. The moment didn't just mark time, it cut time into a clear 'before' and 'after'. 'Before' was a long night of the mind. Thirty-seven years ago, India had dismantled the political part of it. But it was on June 25, 1983, at Lord's—when a swarthy, sinewy fruit of the loam called Kapil Dev led India to the one-day World Cup—that the defeatism instilled into a colonised people was finally ended. That India awoke to mental freedom.

June 25 was a date with resonance. India had earned its Test status on that day in 1932, the now-obscured legend Mohammed Nissar alighting at



FROM THE ARCHIVES
Jul. 15, 1983

Cover Story
Miracle at Lord's

Like a pride of lions that has smelled blood, the Indian team closed in for the kill. Kapil himself was like a coiled spring, clenching and unclenching his fists, bouncing up and down on his heels. His energy transmitted itself to the rest of the field. Gomes was snapped up by Gavaskar in the slips and an injured Lloyd holed out to Kapil. At 76 for 6, history was in the making.

The tension mounted palpably as a seventh wicket stand between Dujon and Marshall took the score to 119, before it was left to the valiant Mohinder Amarnath, coming back for a second spell, to make the crucial break by bowling Dujon. He followed this up with the wicket of Marshall. Kapil accounted for Roberts and Amarnath deservedly put the final nail in the coffin by accounting for Holding.

–Dilip Bobb with Sreedharan Pillai



"India started the tournament as underdogs. But our fielding and team spirit saw us through. It was the fielding that got us the Prudential Cup"

— KAPIL DEV
to INDIA TODAY after the historic win